



ARISE CREDIT PRO · LEVEL 1: THE CREDIT SHIELD

Fix Your File

The do-it-yourself guide to finding and disputing errors on your credit reports

Your rights in plain English · A line-by-line report audit
8 ready-to-use letters · Timelines, tracker and a 90-day plan

Contents

Chapter	What you get
1 Your Rights	The laws behind every dispute, in plain English
2 Get Your Reports	All three reports for free, plus the specialty files most people miss
3 The Report Audit	A section-by-section checklist for reading a report
4 The Error Hunt	The 20 errors worth looking for, and what to do about each
5 Build Your Dispute	Evidence, online versus mail, and how to write one that works
6 The Letters	8 fill-in-the-blank letters for every common situation
7 After You Send	Deadlines, outcomes, and what to do if an error stays
8 Rebuild While You Wait	The habits that move scores, and a 90-day plan
9 Protect Yourself	Credit repair scams, CPNs and your rights if you hire help
Tools	Dispute tracker, bureau addresses, glossary

Start Here

Your credit reports are files about you, kept by three private companies. The law says those files must be accurate, and it gives you the tools to make them accurate. This guide shows you exactly how to use those tools yourself.

What this guide can do. Walk you through pulling all three reports, reading them line by line, spotting the errors that matter, writing disputes that get taken seriously, and following up until each item is resolved. Everything here is something you are legally allowed to do yourself, for free.

What no guide (and no company) can honestly do. Remove negative information that is accurate and still within its reporting period, or promise you a specific score or timeline. Anyone who promises that is a red flag (see Chapter 9). What you *can* do is make sure every item on your file is correct, complete and reported for the right length of time, and that is often where real progress hides.

How to use this guide

- 1 Read Chapters 1 and 2 once. They take 15 minutes and you will use them for years.
- 2 Pull your three reports (Chapter 2) and print them, or save them as PDFs.
- 3 Work through the Report Audit (Chapter 3) with a highlighter, one report at a time.
- 4 Match each problem you find to a letter in Chapter 6 and send your first round.
- 5 Log everything in the Dispute Tracker (page near the end) and follow Chapter 7.
- 6 While you wait, work the 90-Day Plan (Chapter 8). Good habits count as much as cleanup.

What you will need: about two hours for the first pass, a printer or PDF reader, a highlighter, a folder (paper or digital) for copies, a copy of your photo ID and a recent bill or bank statement showing your address, and a few dollars for certified mail.

CHAPTER 1

Your Rights, in Plain English

Four federal laws do most of the work. You don't need to memorize them, but knowing they exist changes how you write, and how seriously companies treat what you send.

The Fair Credit Reporting Act (FCRA)

The main law for credit reports. It applies to the three nationwide bureaus (Equifax, Experian and TransUnion), to specialty bureaus, and to the companies that report your accounts to them (called **furnishers**: your lenders, card issuers and collectors).

- **The right to see your file.** You can get your reports for free (Chapter 2).
- **The right to dispute.** If you dispute an item as inaccurate or incomplete, the bureau must investigate, usually within **30 days** of receiving your dispute (up to 45 days in some cases, such as when you send more information during the investigation).
- **Your evidence must be considered.** The bureau must pass your dispute and the relevant information you sent to the furnisher, usually within 5 business days.
- **Unverifiable items must go.** Information found to be inaccurate, incomplete, or that can't be verified must be corrected or deleted.
- **Written results.** The bureau must send you the results, usually within 5 business days of finishing, plus a free updated report if anything changed.
- **The right to ask how it was checked.** You can request a description of how the bureau verified the item, including the furnisher's name and contact information if available.
- **Protection against reinsertion.** If a deleted item is put back, the bureau must first get the furnisher to certify it is accurate, and notify you in writing within 5 business days.
- **Time limits.** Most negative items can only be reported for about 7 years; most bankruptcies for up to 10 (see the table in Chapter 4).
- **A statement of dispute.** If an item stays and you still disagree, you can add a short statement (up to 100 words) to your file.
- **Identity theft blocks.** With an identity theft report, bureaus must block fraudulent information, generally within 4 business days.
- **The right to sue.** If a company willfully or negligently breaks the FCRA, you may be able to recover damages and attorney's fees. Many consumer attorneys take these cases without upfront fees.

The Fair Debt Collection Practices Act (FDCPA)

Covers third-party debt collectors (not usually the original lender). Two rights matter most here:

- **Validation.** A collector must send you a validation notice describing the debt. If you dispute in writing within the validation period (generally 30 days after you receive that notice), the collector must stop collecting until it sends you verification.

- **No false reporting.** A collector can't report information it knows (or should know) is false, and if it reports a debt you've disputed, it must report it as disputed.

The Equal Credit Opportunity Act (ECOA)

Lenders can't discriminate based on race, color, religion, national origin, sex, marital status, age, or receiving public assistance. If you're denied credit, you have the right to know the specific reasons.

The Credit Repair Organizations Act (CROA)

Protects you if you ever hire a credit repair company. In short: they must give you a written contract and a 3-business-day right to cancel, they can't charge you before the work is fully performed, and they can't tell you to lie or create a 'new' credit identity. It also requires them to tell you something this guide is built on: **you can dispute inaccurate information yourself, for free.**

The one idea to keep

The law protects **accuracy**. Every dispute in this guide is built on a specific, honest reason an item is wrong, incomplete or unverifiable. That is what gets results, and it keeps you on solid ground. Never dispute something you know is accurate as 'not mine'.

CHAPTER 2

Get Your Reports (Free)

You can't fix what you can't see. Pull all three reports on the same day so you can compare them side by side.

Step 1: Your three main reports

- 1 Go to **AnnualCreditReport.com**. It is the only official site for free reports under federal law. Type the address yourself rather than clicking a link or ad, and be wary of look-alike sites.
- 2 Request all three: Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. All three now offer free reports **every week** through this site.
- 3 Answer the identity questions. If you can't get through online, you can request by phone at 1-877-322-8228 or by mail.
- 4 Save each report as a PDF the moment it opens, and write the date on it. Your report number (on each report) goes on every dispute you send to that bureau.

Reports versus scores

Your free reports don't include a credit score, and you don't need one to start. Scores are calculated from what's in the reports, so fixing the reports is the work. Many banks show a free score; versions differ, so numbers from different places won't match.

Step 2: The specialty files most people never check

These files decide things like whether a bank lets you open a checking account or a landlord approves your application. You have the right to a free copy of many of them every 12 months, and to dispute errors the same way.

File	Used for	Where to request
ChexSystems	Opening bank and credit union accounts	chexsystems.com
Early Warning Services	Bank accounts and payments	earlywarning.com
LexisNexis Risk Solutions	Insurance, some lending and background checks	consumer.risk.lexisnexis.com
Innovis	A fourth credit bureau some lenders use	innovis.com
Tenant screening companies	Rental applications	Ask the landlord which company they used

Step 3: Get organized

- Make one folder per bureau. Every letter, receipt and response goes in it. Once your reports are pulled, consider a free credit freeze at all three bureaus (you can lift it any time).
- Keep copies of everything you send (never mail an original), and start the Dispute Tracker today.

CHAPTER 3

The Report Audit

Go through each report one section at a time with a highlighter. Highlight anything that is wrong, missing, or different from the other two reports.

Section 1: Personal information

- Every name variation: misspellings, names you've never used, a relative's name.
- Every address: any you've never lived at can signal a mixed file or identity theft.
- Social Security number, date of birth, phone numbers and employers.
- *Why it matters:* wrong personal details are often how someone else's accounts end up on your file. Fixing them first makes your other disputes stronger.

Section 2: Accounts (also called tradelines)

For every account, check each of these fields:

Field	What to check
Account name and number	Is it yours? Do you recognize the creditor?
Ownership	Individual, joint, or authorized user, and is that correct?
Date opened	Correct month and year?
Status	Open, closed, paid, charged off, in collection: is it current and correct?
Balance	Does it match your latest statement? A paid account should show \$0.
Credit limit / high balance	A missing limit can make your card look maxed out.
Payment history grid	Is every late mark real? Are months you paid on time shown late?
Date of first delinquency	The date the account first went late and never caught up. It controls how long the item can be reported.
Closed by	If you closed it, it shouldn't say the creditor did (or vice versa).
Remarks	Any comment like 'dispute in progress' or 'included in bankruptcy' should be accurate.

Section 3: Collections

- Is the debt yours, and is the amount right?
- Is the same debt listed more than once (for example by the original creditor *and* a collector with a balance on both)? Only one should show a balance owed.
- Is the date of first delinquency the original one, not the date the collector bought it?
- Is it older than the reporting limit?

Section 4: Public records

Today this is usually limited to bankruptcies. Check the chapter, the filing date, and that accounts included in the bankruptcy show a \$0 balance and say so.

Section 5: Inquiries

- **Hard inquiries** happen when you apply for credit and can be shown for up to 2 years.
- **Soft inquiries** (your own checks, pre-approved offers) don't affect scores.
- Highlight any hard inquiry you didn't authorize. It can be a sign of identity theft.

Section 6: Compare all three reports

Lay the three reports next to each other. Differences in balances, dates, statuses or late payments for the same account are worth a close look: they can't all be right.

Quick audit checklist

- Personal info is correct on all three reports
- Every account belongs to me
- Balances, limits and statuses are current
- Every late payment shown really happened
- No debt is listed twice with a balance
- Every negative item is inside its reporting period
- Every hard inquiry was authorized by me
- Paid, settled and bankruptcy-included accounts show the right status and \$0 balance

CHAPTER 4

The Error Hunt

These are the errors worth looking for. Each one has an honest, specific basis for a dispute. Match what you find to a letter in Chapter 6.

Error	What it looks like	Letter
Not your account	An account you never opened	A (or E if identity theft)
Mixed file	Accounts or addresses from someone with a similar name or SSN	A
Identity theft	Accounts, inquiries or addresses created by someone else	E
Wrong ownership	You're listed as owner on an account where you were only an authorized user	A
Wrong balance	A balance higher than you owe, or a balance on a paid account	A, B
Missing credit limit	No limit shown, so the card looks maxed out	A, B
Incorrect late payment	A month shown late that you paid on time	A, B
Wrong status	Open when closed, unpaid when paid, charged off when settled	A, B
Paid collection still owing	A collection you paid still shows a balance	A, B
Duplicate debt	The same debt with a balance under two companies	A
Re-aged debt	Date of first delinquency moved later, which extends reporting time	A, B
Too old to report	A negative item past its reporting period	A
Bankruptcy not reflected	Discharged accounts still show a balance or as past due	A, B
Wrong personal info	Names, addresses or employers that aren't yours	A
Unauthorized hard inquiry	An inquiry from a lender you never applied with	F
Debt not validated	A collector you don't recognize, or an amount you can't confirm	C
Closed by grantor	Shows the creditor closed an account you closed yourself	A
Medical collection under \$500 or paid	The three bureaus have stopped reporting these	A
Reinserted item	A deleted item came back without notice to you	G
Item verified without fixing	The bureau 'verified' something you proved wrong	H, then Chapter 7

How long items can be reported

Item	Typical reporting limit
Late payments, charge-offs, collections	7 years from the date of first delinquency (for collections and charge-offs, 7 years plus 180 days from that date)
Chapter 7 bankruptcy	Up to 10 years from the filing date
Chapter 13 bankruptcy	Bureaus generally remove it 7 years from filing
Hard inquiries	2 years
Positive accounts in good standing	Can stay indefinitely; closed positive accounts commonly stay about 10 years (good for you)

Important: paying a debt doesn't restart the clock

The reporting period runs from the original date of first delinquency. Paying, settling or a debt being sold to a new collector doesn't reset it. (State rules on how long you can be *sued* for a debt are a separate thing, and in some states a payment can affect them, so check before making a payment on a very old debt.)

CHAPTER 5

Build Your Dispute

A dispute that gets results is specific, documented and easy for the investigator to act on. Here is how to build one.

The five rules of a strong dispute

- 1 One clear reason per item.** 'This balance is wrong: I paid it in full on March 3, 2025' beats 'this account is inaccurate'.
- 2 Show your proof.** Include copies (never originals) of statements, receipts, payoff letters, bankruptcy discharge papers or police and FTC reports.
- 3 Say what the fix is.** Correct the balance to \$0, update the status to 'paid', delete the account, remove the late mark for June 2024.
- 4 Keep it short and calm.** One to two pages. Investigators read thousands. Make yours easy to act on.
- 5 Write it yourself.** Use the letters in Chapter 6 as a starting point, but put the facts in your own words. Copy-paste form letters found online can be flagged as 'frivolous', which lets the bureau decline to investigate.

How many items at once?

Lead with your strongest, best-documented items. Sending a focused letter with a few clear errors is more effective than disputing every negative item on your report at once, which can look like a form-letter campaign. Hold weaker items for a later round.

Online, phone or mail?

Method	Pros	Cons
Online (bureau website)	Fast and free; quick to track	Limited space for your explanation; some sites include terms you agree to; harder to prove exactly what you sent
Phone	Good for simple questions	No paper trail; not recommended for disputes
Certified mail, return receipt	Proof of what you sent and when it arrived; room for full evidence	Costs a few dollars; slower to start

For anything important, we suggest **certified mail with a return receipt**. The receipt date is when the investigation clock starts, and it is your proof if you ever need to escalate.

Dispute with the bureau, the furnisher, or both?

- **Bureau dispute** (Letter A): the standard route. The bureau must investigate and contact the furnisher.

- **Direct furnisher dispute** (Letter B): you can also write directly to the lender or collector that reports the item. Under federal rules they must investigate many kinds of direct disputes about accuracy. This works well when you have the furnisher's own records (statements, payoff letters).
- **Doing both** is allowed and often smart for clear errors. Just keep track of both in your tracker.

Your mailing packet

- The dispute letter, signed and dated
- Copy of your photo ID (driver's license or state ID)
- Copy of a utility bill, bank statement or insurance statement showing your current address
- Copy of the report page with the item highlighted
- Copies of your evidence, each labeled with the item it supports
- Your report number from that bureau

Protect your information

Black out all but the last four digits of account numbers on supporting documents. Include your full SSN only where the bureau requires it to identify you, and only on letters to the bureaus, never in an email or online form you didn't reach by typing the bureau's address yourself.

CHAPTER 6

The Letters

Eight letters for the situations you're most likely to meet. Fill in the brackets, add your facts in your own words, attach your evidence, and keep a copy.

LETTER A

Dispute to a credit bureau

Use for any inaccurate, incomplete or outdated item on a bureau report.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and dispute address from page near the end]

Re: Request to investigate inaccurate information

I am writing to dispute the following information in my credit file. The items are highlighted on the enclosed copy of my report.

1. [Creditor name], account ending [1234]
What is wrong: [e.g., shows a balance of \$850; I paid this account in full on 03/03/2025]
Proof enclosed: [e.g., payoff letter dated 03/05/2025]
Correction requested: [e.g., update balance to \$0, status paid]

2. [Next item, same format]

Under the Fair Credit Reporting Act, please investigate these items, forward my evidence to the furnisher, and correct or delete any information that is inaccurate, incomplete or cannot be verified. Please send me the results in writing and an updated copy of my report.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

LETTER B**Direct dispute to a lender or collector (furnisher)**

Use when you have the company's own records proving the error.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Company name]
[Address for disputes or correspondence,
from your statement or their website]

Re: Dispute of information you report, account ending [1234]

You report information about this account to [Equifax /
Experian / TransUnion]. That information is inaccurate:

[Explain the specific error, e.g., my June 2024 payment is
reported 30 days late. It was paid on 06/10/2024, before the
due date of 06/15/2024. Bank statement enclosed.]

Please investigate, correct the information you report, and
notify every credit bureau you report to of the correction.
Please confirm the outcome in writing.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your
evidence]

LETTER C**Debt validation request to a collector**

Send within 30 days of the collector's first notice (the validation period) when you don't recognize a debt or the amount.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Collection agency name]
[Address from their letter]

Re: Reference number [from their letter]

I dispute this debt and request validation. Please provide:

- The name of the original creditor
- The amount owed, with an itemization of interest and fees
- Proof that you own this debt or are authorized to collect it
- A copy of the last statement from the original creditor

Until you provide verification, please stop collection, and if you report this debt to any credit bureau, report it as disputed. Please communicate with me in writing only.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

(Do not admit the debt is yours or offer a payment in this letter.)

LETTER D**Request to remove an outdated item**

Use when a negative item is past its reporting period.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and dispute address]

Re: Information reported beyond the time allowed

The following item is past the reporting period allowed by the Fair Credit Reporting Act and should be deleted:

[Creditor], account ending [1234]
Date of first delinquency: [month/year, with proof if you have it]

Please delete this item and send me written confirmation and an updated copy of my report.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

LETTER E

Identity theft block request

Use with an FTC Identity Theft Report from IdentityTheft.gov.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and address]

Re: Request to block information resulting from identity theft

I am a victim of identity theft. The following information in my file is the result of identity theft and was not opened, used or authorized by me:

1. [Creditor], account ending [1234], opened [date]
2. [Inquiry from (company) on (date)]

Enclosed is my FTC Identity Theft Report and proof of my identity. Under Section 605B of the Fair Credit Reporting Act, please block this information from my file and notify the furnishers. Please confirm in writing.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

LETTER F

Unauthorized hard inquiry

Use for an inquiry you didn't authorize. Write to the bureau, and optionally the company.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and dispute address]

Re: Dispute of unauthorized inquiry

My report shows a hard inquiry by [company] on [date]. I did not apply for credit with this company or authorize it to access my report. Please investigate and remove this inquiry, and send me the results in writing.

[If you suspect identity theft, also use Letter E.]

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

LETTER G

Reinserted item

Use when an item that was deleted reappears.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and dispute address]

Re: Reinsertion of previously deleted information

On [date], you notified me that [creditor], account ending [1234], was deleted from my file (copy enclosed). It now appears again on my report dated [date]. I did not receive the written notice of reinsertion required by the Fair Credit Reporting Act.

Please provide the furnisher's certification of accuracy and the notice required by law, or delete the item. Please respond in writing.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

LETTER H

Request for method of verification

Use when a bureau 'verified' an item you proved was wrong.

[Your full name]
[Street address]
[City, State ZIP]
[Date of birth] [Last 4 of SSN or full SSN if required]
[Report number from this bureau]

[Date]

[Bureau name and dispute address]

Re: Request for description of reinvestigation procedure

On [date] I disputed [creditor], account ending [1234], with evidence that [brief description]. Your results dated [date] say the item was verified.

Under Section 611(a)(7) of the Fair Credit Reporting Act, please send me a description of the procedure used to verify this item, including the business name, address and phone number of the furnisher contacted.

Sincerely,

[Signature]
[Printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, highlighted report page, [list your evidence]

Bonus: the goodwill letter

If a late payment is **accurate**, you can't dispute it, but you can ask. A goodwill letter politely asks the lender to remove an accurate late mark as a courtesy, usually after a long record of on-time payments since. The lender has no obligation to agree, so keep it short, honest and specific: what happened, what has changed, and how long you've paid on time since.

CHAPTER 7

After You Send

Mark your calendar the day your return receipt comes back. That's day one.

The timeline

When	What should happen
Day 1	Bureau receives your dispute (date on your return receipt)
Within about 5 business days	Bureau forwards your dispute and evidence to the furnisher
Within 30 days (sometimes 45)	Investigation must be finished
Within 5 business days after that	You receive written results, plus an updated report if anything changed
Day 35 to 50	If you've heard nothing, pull a fresh report and send a follow-up

The four outcomes, and what to do next

Result	What it means	Your next step
Deleted	The item is gone	Save the letter. Check future reports for reinsertion (Letter G).
Updated	Corrected in some way	Check it was corrected the way you asked. If not, dispute what's still wrong.
Verified	The furnisher said it's accurate	See the escalation ladder below.
Frivolous	The bureau declined to investigate	They must tell you why within 5 business days. Resend with the specific information they say is missing, in your own words.

The escalation ladder (when an error stays)

- 1 Dispute again with new evidence.** A second dispute with nothing new can be called frivolous. Add something.
- 2 Dispute directly with the furnisher** (Letter B) if you haven't already.
- 3 Ask how it was verified** (Letter H).
- 4 File a complaint with the CFPB** at consumerfinance.gov/complaint. Companies must respond, and complaints often get a fresh look from someone more senior.
- 5 Contact your state attorney general's** consumer protection office.
- 6 Add a statement of dispute** (up to 100 words) to your file so lenders see your side.
- 7 Talk to a consumer protection attorney** if a company keeps reporting information you've proven wrong. FCRA cases can include attorney's fees, and many attorneys offer free consultations.

CHAPTER 8

Rebuild While You Wait

Cleaning up errors removes what shouldn't be there. Building good history adds what should. Do both at the same time.

What credit scores pay attention to

FICO, the most widely used score, publishes the general weight of each factor. Your own mix depends on your file.

Factor	Approximate weight	What helps
Payment history	35%	Paying every account on time, every month
Amounts owed	30%	Low card balances compared to your limits
Length of credit history	15%	Keeping older accounts open
New credit	10%	Applying only when you need to
Credit mix	10%	Handling different types of credit well over time

The habits that matter most

- **Never miss a payment again.** Set every account to autopay at least the minimum. One new 30-day late can outweigh months of cleanup.
- **Keep card balances low.** Try to keep each card, and your total, well below 30% of the limit, and lower is better. Paying before the statement date lowers the balance that gets reported.
- **Don't close your oldest cards** just because they're paid off. They help your history length and your available credit.
- **Space out applications.** Each one can add a hard inquiry. Apply when you have a reason.
- **If you have no open cards,** a secured card (backed by your own deposit) or a credit-builder loan from a bank or credit union can start new positive history. Use it lightly and pay it in full.

Your 90-day plan

When	Do this
Week 1	Pull all three reports and specialty files. Freeze your credit. Start your folder and tracker.
Week 2	Complete the Report Audit. List every error with its evidence.
Week 3	Send round 1 (your strongest items) by certified mail. Set up autopay on every account.
Weeks 4 to 6	Gather evidence for round 2. Pay card balances down before statement dates.
Weeks 6 to 8	Results arrive. Log them. Check every change against what you asked for.
Weeks 8 to 10	Send round 2 and any escalations (Chapter 7).
Weeks 10 to 13	Pull fresh reports. Compare with your starting point. Plan your next 90 days.

CHAPTER 9

Protect Yourself

Credit trouble attracts scams. Knowing the warning signs protects your money and your file.

Red flags of a credit repair scam

- Asks you to pay **before any work is done**. That's illegal under the CROA.
- **Guarantees** a score, a number of points, or that negative items will be removed.
- Tells you to dispute **accurate** information as 'not mine'.
- Tells you **not to contact the bureaus yourself**, or hides that you can dispute for free.
- Offers a '**CPN**' (credit privacy number) or 'new credit identity'. Using a number other than your own SSN on a credit application can be a federal crime. Walk away.
- Won't give you a **written contract** with a 3-business-day cancellation right.

If you decide to hire help

A legitimate company should give you, before you sign: a written contract describing the services, the total cost and payment terms, how long it will take, and your right to cancel within 3 business days; and a written statement of your rights under state and federal law. It should never charge you before the work it's charging for is done.

Your best defense: a habit

- Pull your reports a few times a year, even when things are going well.
- Keep your credit frozen when you're not applying for anything.
- Read every letter from a lender or collector, and answer in writing.
- Keep your folder. The paper trail is your protection.

Dispute Tracker

Copy this page as many times as you need. One row per item, per bureau.

Item / account	Bureau or company	Letter	Date sent	Received	Result	Next step

Addresses and Contacts

These are the published dispute addresses at the time of writing. Always check the bureau's own website for the current address before you mail anything.

Bureau	Dispute by mail	Online
Equifax	Equifax Information Services LLC P.O. Box 740256 Atlanta, GA 30374-0256	equifax.com
Experian	Experian P.O. Box 4500 Allen, TX 75013	experian.com
TransUnion	TransUnion Consumer Solutions P.O. Box 2000 Chester, PA 19016-2000	transunion.com

Resource	Use it for
AnnualCreditReport.com / 1-877-322-8228	Free reports from all three bureaus
IdentityTheft.gov	FTC Identity Theft Report and recovery plan
consumerfinance.gov/complaint	CFPB complaints about bureaus, lenders and collectors
Your state attorney general	State consumer protection complaints
optoutprescreen.com / 1-888-567-8688	Stop pre-approved credit offers

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Credit bureau	A company that collects and sells credit information (Equifax, Experian, TransUnion).
Furnisher	A company that reports your account information to the bureaus.
Tradeline	One account as it appears on your report.
Date of first delinquency	When an account first went late and never caught back up. It sets the reporting clock.
Charge-off	When a lender writes a debt off as a loss. You may still owe it.
Utilization	Your card balances divided by your card limits.
Hard inquiry	A lender's check of your credit when you apply. Can affect scores for a short time.
Credit freeze	A free lock that stops new creditors from seeing your report.
Validation notice	A collector's required notice describing a debt and your right to dispute it.

Where to Go From Here

You now have everything you need to fix your file yourself. If you'd rather have someone do the work with you, here's how the 7Band family can help.

Level 1: The Credit Shield	Arise Credit Pro runs the dispute process for you as described in this guide. Start with a free consultation at arisecreditpro.com .
Levels 2 and 3: The Business Firewall and Capital Readiness	East Consulting LLC helps you set up a business the right way and get it ready for capital. eastconsultingllc.com
The whole map	THE FLOW is a free weekly webinar that walks through every level. theflow.7bandfinancialagency.com

Important

This guide is for education only and is not legal advice. It reflects federal law and bureau practices at the time of writing; laws, rules and addresses change, and your state may give you additional rights. Results depend on the facts of your file; no specific outcome, score or timeline is promised. For advice about your situation, talk to a consumer protection attorney.

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